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DEFERRED EXTERMINATION

SEVERAL AUTHORS WHO ARE CRITICAL of the US drone wars have approvingly quoted the US Army general Stanley McChrystal. Hugh Gusterson, for instance, quotes McChrystal in the epigraph to the first chapter of his book *Drone*: “To the United States a drone strike seems to have very little risk and very little pain,” McChrystal states. “At the receiving end it feels like war. Americans have got to understand that.”¹ He claims, and this is a claim cited as strong evidence against the military use of drones later in Gusterson’s book as well as by other anti-drone writers, that by using drones “you create a tremendous amount of resentment inside populations . . . because of the way it appears and feels. . . . What seems like a panacea to the messiness of war is not that at all. . . . And wars are ultimately decided in the minds of populations.”² There is an implicit reference here back to the Vietnam-era claim about the necessity of winning over “hearts and minds.” McChrystal’s critique of the drone is based on a conviction that the enemy matters and that to win is somehow to win the enemy over, to get it to acknowledge and live with the superiority of the victor, not just militarily but also culturally. On an even more basic level, McChrystal sees war as about winning, perhaps even as about ending war. Chris Woods quotes McChrystal as saying that “we’re going to lose the fucking war if we

don't stop killing civilians."³ In this sense, McChrystal remains within the paradigm of the theory of war established by Carl von Clausewitz, according to which the aim of war is to make the enemy submit to one's own terms and to thus end armed conflict.⁴

McChrystal's comments, while comforting to certain anti-drone writers, may simply reflect a misunderstanding of what the drone is and the kind of neocolonial political technology it represents. To be comforted by McChrystal, one must think that the drone is a mere weapon of war, that it does not fundamentally change the kind of war one can wage. However, the drone does just this. The point of drone warfare is that one does not need to win over the enemy, nor does one need to end a war. The remoteness and asymmetry of drone warfare means that it can potentially become permanent, such that neither the hearts nor minds of the enemy are important. Insofar as one can both observe and destroy, with impunity, the bodies of modern neocolonial subjects, their hearts and minds are no longer relevant. Blurring the boundary between war and peace and undoing the dialectical opposition between friend and enemy are two aspects of drone warfare. They produce an enemy who cannot and need not become a friend.

Another facet of drone warfare, as many critics have noticed, is that it destabilizes notions of presence. As I explored in the previous chapter, one of the reasons that the drone does this is that it is a colonial political technology. Colonialism has always been about ruling at a distance and, in doing so, undoing the presence of the colonial power to itself. Eyal Weizman has recently demonstrated that Israel's occupation of Palestine is the most advanced form of neocolonialism because of the way it enforces a separation of the occupied and occupying populations in a three-dimensional political topography that he calls a politics of verticality. He has also demonstrated the way that a logic of the lesser evil, in which constant low-intensity violence (often perpetrated by drones) is justified because it is supposedly a more humane alternative to massively destructive wars, has prolonged and perpetuated war and violence.⁵ The present of war is thus radically extended, with every drone strike or every use of rubber bullets justified as an act of restraint rather than violence.⁶ The specter of a massively destructive violence thus perpetuates violence in the present and maintains what seems to be an untenable political situation by a constant deferral of any long-term solution through a continual series of acts of

low-intensity violence. The drone is the primary weapon in the cutting-edge form of neocolonialism represented by the Israeli occupation of Palestine.

If the conflict between Israel and Palestine is the frontline of drone warfare and neocolonialism in the twenty-first century, Jonathan Swift's *Gulliver's Travels*, of 1726, explores in a hyperbolic way the consequences both of a politics of verticality and of a logic of violence that perpetuates war. Indeed, Swift explicitly discusses a political structure in which certain populations are considered as not deserving of genocide, while also not being granted any kind of freedom or protection from state violence. He predicts our twenty-first century situation: a state of war punctuated by acts of low-intensity violence that is not supposed to end. It is perhaps unsurprising that *Gulliver's Travels*, an Enlightenment text intensely concerned with the various technologies of colonialism (from telescopes to ships to gunpowder) imagines, in the weaponized flying island of Laputa, a terrifyingly prescient version of the drone. At the same time, Swift's work also relies on a satiric procedure that dislocates both spatial and temporal presence. Like drone warfare, the satiric method of *Gulliver's Travels* undoes the presence of the colonial power to itself. For its part, the drone does this by mediating between the territory of the occupying power, from which attacks are launched, and the occupied territory, which feels the force of the attacks. As it does this, as various writers have shown, the mediating technology of the drone makes it seem for drone operators that the violence of war is right here at home in what is theoretically a territory removed from violent conflict.⁷ For those living under drones, on the other hand, territory is remotely occupied, without boots on the ground but with all the present violence of war.

In *Gulliver's Travels*, Swift's satiric procedure undoes presence in a different way, and in doing so it produces an Enlightenment theory of remote-control colonialism. Swift's other Englands in the first three books of the *Travels* are spatially removed from England and yet (within the fiction of the satire) contemporaneous with it. There is thus a dislocation of the space of England. This dislocation of space is even more complex in book 3, in which Laputa is layered on top of Balnibarbi. These spatial dislocations, however, are only a part of the way in which *Gulliver's Travels* dislocates presence. Brobdingnag and Lilliput, for instance, look like different versions of England. Lilliput is an allegory of England's present, while

Brobbingnag is an idealized version of England. Crucially, however, both these imaginary Englands exist without (or before) the invention of gunpowder.⁸ Gulliver's descriptions of the wondrous destructive capabilities of gunpowder, furthermore, make this technology seem like something that has not been fully integrated into the English present, a present potentiality of destruction that still seems too horribly futuristic.

Most importantly, however, the final book of *Gulliver's Travels* presents us with a temporal dislocation that profoundly resembles our own. For the Houyhnhnms, the rational horses who rule over a race of degenerate humans called Yahoos, only one debate disturbs their perfectly administered society. They cannot decide whether to exterminate the Yahoos, and in lieu of deciding, they keep them indefinitely in subjugation. This indefinite suspension of the decision is in contradiction to their own reason, and in suspending or delaying a definitive act of violence, the Houyhnhnms create a quasi-permanent state of racial domination. The present is not present to itself but is rather the time of suspension, a temporality that always holds off the destructive future. What Swift describes in *Gulliver's Travels*, I will argue, is precisely the temporality of drone warfare. Drone warfare suspends a high-intensity, potentially genocidal conflict by maintaining a permanent low-intensity war. It puts off both a decision about peace, or the cessation of war altogether, and a decision about a higher-intensity war that would definitively alter the relations between states and peoples. In doing so, the drone warfare prosecuted by Western powers maintains a racialized colonial relation between the sovereign powers that use drones and the territories of subjects who live under them, between those who are subject to drone attacks and those who are not. This, even more than his imagination of a destructive remote-control flying island, is the final relevance of Swift's work to the world of drones. His account of the colonial world is explicitly organized by racial division, and the immediate effect of the perpetual suspension of the decision about the Yahoos is to both produce and maintain this division.

SYMMETRY AND ASYMMETRY

If colonialism is about the dislocation of presence, it is also fundamentally about the relationship between symmetry and asymmetry. Specifically, it relies on an asymmetry of force for the maintenance of the colonial relation. *Gulliver's Travels* too is concerned with the disruption of symmetry, and this forms both a theme of the satire and part of Swift's satiric method. This is relevant to the phenomenon of drone warfare because it is the most obvious and chilling instantiation of asymmetrical warfare. While causing such terror, drones are in fact relatively weak as far as weapons, especially aerial ones, go. Early Predator drones had modified snowmobile engines.⁹ They remain quite slow and liable to be blown off course by moderate winds, and like its younger sibling the Reaper, the Predator is easy for any half-way competent air force or air defense system to detect and shoot down.¹⁰ Indeed, even the Hellfire missiles with which these drones are fitted are routinely described by drone pilots and US military personnel as small weapons.¹¹ (Compared with the huge power of the bombs and missiles that can be launched from more conventional planes, this is undoubtedly true, although one wonders how small these missiles feel on the ground, where they can destroy a couple of houses.) In this sense, what is disturbing about drones is not their powerful, destructive capability (as it is, for instance, in the case of nuclear weapons); it is rather that such a relatively weak weapon can wreak such havoc and be so effective. This is not merely a technological problem but a political one. It is only because of a neocolonial political system that this technology is an effective method of control. Drones are effective only against enemies who lack the kind of infrastructure associated with a twentieth-century (let alone twenty-first-century) state military apparatus. Indeed, what is striking about drones is that they are effective at all. It is only a geopolitical field characterized by a heavily racialized asymmetry that makes drones potent weapons. Any account of the drone, then, needs to reckon with the problem of asymmetry, the radical distance (which is not merely physical but also political) between those who live under drones and those who direct them.

It is in this context of asymmetrical power that Swift's imagination of the island of Laputa is most interesting. The island of Laputa itself hovers over Balnibarbi, the territory below it, and is moved by means of a powerful

magnet attracted to the land. The king of Laputa resides on the island, engaged with his nobility in mathematical and musical pursuits, and uses the power of this remote flying machine to control and subdue the population below. This remote flying machine has routinely been taken for a metaphor of colonial control. Srinivas Aravamudan, for example, sees the Flying Island as representative of the colonial “oppression engendered by state structures.”¹² Christopher Loar’s argument that “Laputa offers us an image of a superiority that is merely technological, devoid of the power to civilize except through violence” draws attention to the asymmetry of power between Laputa and the territory over which it hovers.¹³ Any reading of the asymmetry of Laputa must also take into account the way that the form or technique of Swift’s satire, as well as the content of the entire book, is dependent precisely on exploring the relationship between symmetrical and asymmetrical political relations, as well as the reciprocal and nonreciprocal use of force. Swift prominently uses as part of his satire figures of symmetry, such as the differences in size, relative to Gulliver himself, of the peoples of Lilliput and Brobdingnag. However, Swift also demonstrates, and this is the radicality of his text as it veers toward the radical edge of Enlightenment thought, that the opposition between symmetry and asymmetry is not itself symmetrical. There is no higher level on which symmetry can be balanced against asymmetry, no dialectical sublation of these terms that would create a new balance or stasis. More practically, one could say that no political relationship of asymmetry can lead to or produce a new form of community that would no longer rely on asymmetrical violence. Asymmetry is instead pertinent to an inextinguishable racist colonialism that both drives and undoes the Enlightenment project of the construction of order, balance, reciprocity, and symmetry.

Gulliver’s arrival in Lilliput inaugurates Swift’s concern with reciprocal and nonreciprocal political relations. Gulliver immediately realizes the asymmetry of force that holds between himself and the tiny Lilliputians. He confesses, upon being partially unrestrained so that he can drink, that he “was often tempted, while they were passing backwards and forwards on my Body, to seize Forty or Fifty of the first that came within my reach, and dash them against the Ground.”¹⁴ His immense power, rather than any particular animosity toward the Lilliputians, tempts him to kill them en masse, as if this asymmetry of force by itself produces a radical distinction

between the value of their lives and his own. Gulliver is restrained from this temptation, however, by a kind of reciprocity. First, he has felt the sting of their arrows, and he worries that “what I had felt . . . might not be the worst they could do,” but he also interprets his own submissive behavior when first addressed by the Lilliputians to consist of a “Promise of Honour,” meaning that he was “bound by the Laws of Hospitality” to them (26). Gulliver’s fear of the potential power of the Lilliputians to wound him and his sense of honor thus produce a reciprocity that ameliorates the asymmetry of force. Gulliver, indeed, muses that things might have been different. He says that had he not been treated with respect, but attacked, he would have broken his bonds in rage and fallen upon his captors “after which, as they were not able to make Resistance, so they could expect no Mercy” (28). Even mercy, here, somewhat counterintuitively, is made a function of a reciprocity of force, and the specter of killing without mercy forms the asymmetrical, nonreciprocal element of the politics of *Gulliver’s Travels*. In the first of Gulliver’s voyages Swift thus contains, without entirely suppressing, the destructive asymmetry of force that threatens mass destruction and the reduction of the lives of Lilliputians to the value of mere insects. In our twenty-first-century context it is drone warfare that supposedly contains or holds off mass destruction, while at the same time acting as that which delivers violence and maintains war.

This concern with containing merciless destruction, the potentially horrifying effect of asymmetry, is characteristic of the satiric method of the first two books of *Gulliver’s Travels*. Indeed, the second voyage to Brobdingnag is like a symmetrical reversal of Gulliver’s time in Lilliput. Gulliver is now, relative to the Brobdingnagians, the same size as the Lilliputians were relative to him. Consequently, his life is precarious and little valued. Gulliver reflects upon his own mortification at being so small and inconsiderable but is more concerned that “as human Creatures are observed to be more savage and cruel in Proportion to their Bulk, what could I expect but to be a Morsel in the Mouth of the first among these enormous Barbarians who should happen to see me?” (82–83). Gulliver thus associates size and power with cruelty and the kind of abandonment of mercy that he himself had considered while in Lilliput. He also reflects that “undoubtedly Philosophers are in the right when they tell us, that nothing is great or little otherwise than by Comparison” (83). This comparatism is

what makes the satire of the first two books work, as if a change in perspective, like looking at the world through one or the other end of a telescope, could change or revalue the world entirely. Gulliver's arrival in Brobdingnag, then, has a certain kind of symmetry with the first voyage, as Gulliver changes from "the greatest Prodigy that ever appeared in the World" (82) to being handled like a "small dangerous Animal" (83), just as Gulliver himself would have handled a weasel in England.

Even within this symmetry produced by the second voyage, however, Swift maintains the specter of asymmetry, especially in regard to politics, and destruction. In his continued quest to increase his value in front of the giants who are almost beyond comparison with him, Gulliver offers to the king of Brobdingnag the gift of gunpowder. He promises a weapon that "would not only destroy whole Ranks of an Army at once, but batter the strongest Walls to the Ground, sink down Ships with a thousand Men in each, to the bottom of the Sea; and, when linked together by a Chain, would cut through Masts and Rigging, divide hundreds of Bodies in the middle, and lay all waste before them" (124). Because Gulliver is in a country that is another present to England, contemporaneous with it but sharing none of its history, Swift can have Gulliver describe this weapon not as if it were really in existence but as a wonder of the future. This is for the benefit not merely of the Brobdingnagian king but also of Swift's English readers. This kind of description gives the impression that the destructive power of gunpowder is something that Swift's present has somehow not caught up with, a technology that, though present, is still in front of us, of the future. This is also the tone Swift will adopt in describing the not-yet-in-existence form of airpower represented by the Flying Island of Laputa. Moreover, it is precisely the way we live under drones. They are technologies of the present that present to us a future not yet realized and yet somehow already here with us. However present this present is, it is still in the future precisely because we do not know how to deal with it, to understand it now. Just as the weapons of destruction present to Swift in eighteenth-century warfare instantiate, in the present, a future of unimaginable destruction, drones are already everywhere around us, seeing and killing remotely.¹⁵ They are the vision of a future already here and thus represent an irrevocable split in our own present.

Unfortunately, we do not have the recourse of the king of Brobdingnag, who can simply deny the future that already exists in the present. He

rejects Gulliver's offer, "struck with Horror at . . . the Proposal [Gulliver] had made" (125). The king is horrified not only at the death and destruction gunpowder would bring but at the radical political asymmetry that it would allow, making him "absolute Master of the Lives, the Liberties, and the Fortunes of his People" (125). Being simply from another present, the king can abuse Gulliver as a "grovelling . . . Insect" inhumanly "unmoved at all the Scenes of Blood and Desolation" he describes. Not being from a present already imbued with this future of destruction, the king can say to Gulliver that he "would rather lose half his Kingdom than be privy to such a Secret" (125). The king's impossible, gigantic virtue is a way for Swift to sneer at the possibility of any such virtue in his own present. It is also, though, a fantasy of being able to deny that the future that scares us is already here.¹⁶ The stark descriptions of the destructive power of gunpowder seem like the fantasy of a future even as we know they are actualities. Precisely because we do not live in another present, but already in this destructive future, we cannot escape it, and the king of Brobdingnag is both an impossible moral paragon and another present, mercifully insulated from the already present future horrors of Swift's readers' world.¹⁷ The escape from the peril of radical political asymmetry is thus accomplished only because of an unlikely giant virtue, which lives in the temporality of a present that is insulated from the present-future of gunpowder.

LAPUTA IS (NOT) A DRONE

Once Gulliver travels to Laputa, the question of asymmetry and nonreciprocity in political relations becomes stark and unavoidable. It is precisely through the metaphor of a flying island, which doubles as both royal territory and weapon, that Swift sharpens his discussion of asymmetry. What is interesting about Swift's Laputa is the way in which his metaphor of the flying island (to the extent that it is a metaphor) goes beyond its various applications or referents. While Swift scholars have debated whether the island refers to England's position vis-à-vis Ireland or to European colonialism more generally, I want to focus less on the tenor of the metaphor than on the vehicle itself. As Aravamudan argues with relation to Gulliver's fascination with horses after his return from Houyhnhnm-land, Gulliver "transgresses the rule of abstract metaphor by insisting on materialist

metamorphosis.” He wants not just equine beauty but “equine dung and odor around him as well.” In this sense, Aravamudan argues, “the vehicle of the metaphor is just as important as the tenor.”¹⁸ The flying vehicle of Laputa too resonates beyond any particular tenor of the metaphor. Flight, and particularly aerial occupation, flies out of the context of all possible historical referents (even those attributed to contemporaneous accounts of flying machines, such as those so carefully explored by Loar).¹⁹ If we take the metaphor literally, insisting that what is important in it is the fact that Swift creates a remote weaponized flying machine, we see how it explores and anticipates precisely the kind of remote occupation characteristic of drone colonialism. In this sense, what is most interesting about Laputa is not the historical situation it may refer to but the radical, asymmetrical political potential unleashed by a weaponized aerial vehicle. The flying island of Laputa is able to dominate the land below it because of its mobility and because it is almost invulnerable. Indeed, it is because the island is almost (and in Swift’s imagination of the drone the difference this “almost” makes is important) independent from the land it dominates. Laputa thus represents a political relation that is almost (but at least in Swift, not quite) a relation of occupation without any reciprocal relation, a remote occupation that promises, almost, the drones of the future.

Gulliver’s first vision of Laputa is as an obscurity. Rather than seeing the island, he sees the sky darkening “in a manner very different from what happens by the Interposition of a cloud” (146).²⁰ Upon looking through his telescope, Gulliver is astonished “to behold an Island in the Air, inhabited by Men, who were able (as it should seem) to raise, sink, or put it in a Progressive Motion, as they pleased” (146). This first vision is a kind of reverse of the aerial visions from above that have become standard in histories of aviation, and of the military development of airpower.²¹ Gulliver’s telescope, his “Pocket-Perspective,” itself a technology designed to make the remote near (or, in reverse, to make the near remote), now renders him astonished and powerless at the sight of the mass of land above him. The island is a technology of a different order than the telescope. It is a “firm Substance” that is moved about, and not merely an alteration of perspective. If the telescope itself is an important navigational, military, and colonial technology, the flying island increases the potential for military action at a distance and is able to navigate above, if not independent of, the elements

of the land and sea. Laputa joins the telescope's ability to bring the remote near with the potential for direct military action, just as the Predator drone was revolutionary for being able to combine surveillance with bombing. Laputa represents the potential for remote occupation joined to military action, and its airborne nature anticipates the colonial matrix as the laboratory for the use of aerial warfare.²²

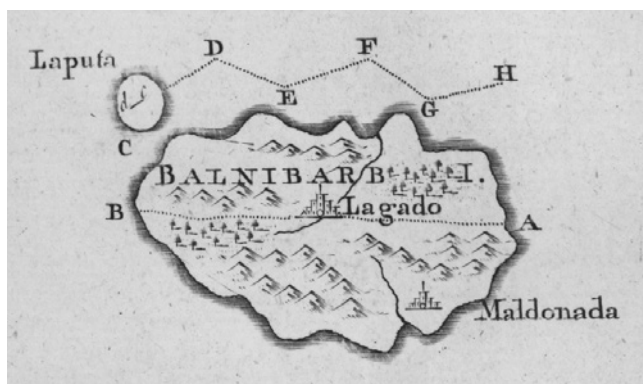
The technology of Laputa allows it to hover above Balnibarbi and to move, raise, and lower itself with reference to the territory below. The island functions through magnets, with the movement of a large lodestone in the center of the island determining its direction. Thus, the specific technology of the flying island links it to the territory below. Similarly, the political structure of Laputan society means that it remains strongly related to the territory below.²³ Gulliver tells us that the king could render himself absolute were it not for the fact that the ministry, "having their Estates below on the Continent," will not join with him in any plan for the absolute "enslaving of their Country" (159). The Laputans, if perhaps not the king, thus have a political stake in the country below. What happens to it matters to them. The technology that links Laputa to the territory below thus neatly represents the colonial political structure of the country. It is in this sense that Laputa is not quite as remote as the drone. This becomes even clearer in Swift's description of the reciprocity between Balnibarbi and the flying island.

While the king is able to use the island as a form of asymmetrical airpower to dominate the land below, this asymmetry is not total. Laputa is vulnerable, even as a military engine. Swift goes to some lengths to demonstrate that there is not a total nonreciprocity of force between Laputa and the terrestrial cities of Balnibarbi. Gulliver describes two ways in which the king can use the island of Laputa to discipline his subjects: "The first, and mildest, course is by keeping the Island hovering over such a [rebellious] Town, and the Lands about it, whereby he can deprive them of the Benefit of the Sun and the Rain, and consequently afflict the Inhabitants with Death and Diseases. And if the Crime deserve it, they are at the same time pelted from above with great Stones, against which they have no Defence but by creeping into Cellars or Caves, while the Roofs of their Houses are beaten to Pieces" (159). This "mild" course of discipline demonstrates Swift's prescient vision of airpower, in which, simultaneously, the surface

of the earth is flattened out and becomes open and vulnerable to attack against which there is “no Defence”; and political space becomes three-dimensional, with the air and underground being occupied in different ways than the surface of the ground itself. Swift’s Balnibarbi, because of the aerial threat of Laputa, looks something like the hollow land of Palestine described by Eyal Weizman, in which Israel’s politics of verticality works by turning territory into a three-dimensional space of separation.

Indeed, Weizman’s claim in *Hollow Land* is that the politics of verticality makes the work of traditional cartography inadequate to describe the division of territory in which certain levels of the earth pertain to an occupier, and others to an occupied people. Such a claim is anticipated in Swift’s three-dimensional map of Laputa and Balnibarbi. Readers of *Gulliver’s Travels* will be familiar with the maps Swift appends to the beginning of each of Gulliver’s journeys, all of which are parodies of relatively conventional maps that show the land and sea from an aerial, two-dimensional perspective, with the addition of the odd ship or sea monster. The map of Balnibarbi is a little different. Since it is not possible to draw the island from above without obscuring the land below, the map in fact has two axes transposed into one. As is conventional, the top of the page represents north, with Balnibarbi presented as a flat surface covered with mountains, forests, and towns. However, the top of the page also represents height, with the island of Laputa and the course that it charts placed above Balnibarbi on this latter axis but not on the former. In other words, Laputa is above Balnibarbi not because it is further north but because it is higher. In this sense, Laputa’s politics of verticality, a phrase used by both Weizman and Achille Mbembe, distorts cartography, and it twists the two-dimensional map into three dimensions, asking us to see it along two axes.²⁴ Furthermore, the map of Laputa above Balnibarbi is a map of movement, showing us how the island progresses over the territory below it. Swift thus invents a new cartographic language to deal with the politics of verticality, demonstrating that thinking through the drone necessitates thinking through the problem of territory and occupation in more than two—perhaps, if we take into account duration, more than three—dimensions.

In Balnibarbi, the king’s mild course of action would send subjects into hiding and take away their modes of livelihood. However, it is not, Gulliver tells us, the ultimate recourse of the Laputan king. The most extreme of



Map of Laputa and Balnibarbi, from Jonathan Swift, *Travels into Several Remote Nations of the World* (London, 1726)

the king's violent measures against his populace is "letting the Island drop directly on [the inhabitants'] Heads, which makes a universal Destruction both of Houses and Men" (160). Swift's imagination thus goes beyond the permanent disciplining of subjects from the air, toward mass destruction and killing. Importantly, however, "this is an Extremity to which the Prince is seldom driven, neither indeed is he willing to put it in Execution" (160). This is for two distinct reasons. First, the king and his ministry are at odds on the use of the island as a military engine. While the king would proceed to this extremity, his ministers, whose estates and interests are on the island below, are reluctant to do so. There is thus a distinction between the military, or technical, aspect of the technology of the island and its political technology. The island's technical capacities mean it could enslave or massacre the people of Balnibarbi. However, the political organization of this particular colonial relation involves a reciprocity between the colonizing force who live on the island and the territories below.

The ministers depend on Balnibarbi for their own wealth and thus cannot crush it absolutely. In this sense, in any discussion of the potential of aerial technology to work as a political force, one must take into account not only the technology itself but also the political situation that makes its use possible. This means that the politics of verticality, discussed in much recent criticism, has to do not only with geography or topography; it also has to do with a sovereign control that would govern without grounded intermediaries. In Laputa, the ministers are these intermediaries, and the

link between the sovereign and his flying island of destruction is thus to some extent ameliorated. In our world, drones themselves are the technology of mediation, acting as the intermediary between those living under drones and those who control them. The mechanization of the relationship of mediation removes any reciprocal stake in the territory for those who patrol it. This also means that in terms of political technology, the relation between Balnibarbi and Laputa is much less asymmetrical than that between, for instance, the United States and Waziristan.

The second reason that the king is wary of proceeding to the last extreme is more a matter of military than political technology. His island is not invulnerable. He fears that “if the Town intended to be destroyed should have in it any tall Rocks . . . or if it abound in high Spires or Pillars of Stone, a sudden fall might endanger the Bottom or under Surface of the Island” (160). The king thus makes the island always descend with “great gentleness,” ostensibly out of a “Tenderness for his subjects” but really “for fear of breaking the Adamantine bottom” (160).

Even more importantly, however, the passage concerning the rebellion of Lindalino, never published during Swift’s lifetime and often read as an allegory of Swift’s own resistance to the destructive colonial scheme of Wood’s halfpence, indicates that there is a point at which even the most murderous force of the flying island can be reciprocated.²⁵ The people of Lindalino build four towers and place on top of each, in addition to a large rock, both lodestones and explosives, aiming either to fix Laputa in place or, failing that, to simply blow up the bottom of the island. The king, upon hearing that the people are in rebellion, moves rapidly through his escalating measures, attempting to bring the rebellious city back in line. However, the lodestones interfere with the navigation of the island, and this “Incident broke entirely the King’s Measures and . . . he was forced to give the Town its own Conditions” (162). If this is not enough for Swift to demonstrate the power of resistance to Laputa, he adds that Gulliver was told by a “great Minister, that if the Island had descended so near the Town, as not to be able to raise itself, the Citizens were determined to fix it for ever, to kill the King and all his Servants, and entirely change the Government” (162). If the relation of the flying island to the territories below it is a kind of colonial parable, then, it ends with the metaphor of flight being brought back down to earth and with a fantasy of revolution and bloody revenge. Mass destruction is, Swift seems to say, always a reciprocal possibility.²⁶

BETWEEN UNIVERSAL DESTRUCTION AND PERPETUAL LOW-INTENSITY WARFARE

Although Swift is relentlessly concerned with mass destruction, *Gulliver's Travels* also demonstrates the brutal effectiveness of perpetual low-intensity violence for colonialism. Indeed, it is in relation to this latter form of violence that Swift more nearly imagines the contemporary condition of drone warfare. It is this topic that the remainder of this chapter explores. Especially with the ending of the few paragraphs about Lindalino, Swift merges military and political technology. It is because of, in the case of Lindalino, a reciprocity of force, here a mutual capacity for mass destruction, that the political relation is not entirely nonreciprocal. Part of this has to do with technology in the sense of technics. Laputa remains attached to the ground below it by the force of magnets. It cannot leave the arc of Balnibarbi, and its movement is governed by its attraction to and repulsion from the earth below. This is, of course, a nice metaphor for the relation of political reciprocity that exists between Laputa and its occupied territory. Twenty-first-century drone technology, however, is much more remote from the territory it hovers over, surveys, and attacks. It is also much less destructive than Laputa, a point I will return to. While this kind of remoteness is always deconstructable, in the sense that one must always note a certain territorial dependence of the drone, between Swift's flying island and the Reaper drone there is a qualitative change. The Reaper can hover, invulnerable, over territory for fourteen to thirty hours.²⁷ Refueling (which can be done by manned aircraft, and perhaps soon by other drones) and other terrestrial tasks are performed away from the "battlefield," or occupied territory below.²⁸ The drone's technology, in this sense, makes it much more remote from the place it surveys and occupies than Swift's island.

More importantly, however, the political technology represented by the drone makes this technical remoteness matter. Precisely because there is no (again, this "no" must always be deconstructable) reciprocal relation between the territory and population below and those who control the drones, there is no limit to the asymmetry between drone and target, between occupied territory and occupier. This is a crucial aspect of drone warfare, especially as it eludes most definitions of conventional war, including Elaine Scarry's influential and perspicacious definition of war as reciprocal injuring.²⁹ Without this reciprocity, the drone seems to escape traditional

concepts of warfare. It cleaves much more closely to the paradigm of asymmetrical colonial wars than to that of the kinds of wars between states theorized in most philosophies of war. Even more than a traditional colonialism, however, the drone is fundamentally part of a neocolonial political technology in which remote occupation of territory is possible and desirable precisely because the productive capacity, the capitalization, of the land and citizens below is largely unimportant to the colonial force. It is in this sense that a remote occupation, without “boots on the ground,” is allowed by drone warfare.

As I argued in chapter 2, it is important to maintain the word *occupation* here, even if the more traditional aspects of colonial occupation, such as the extraction of resources or the administration of government, are missing. Writing about an early manifestation of airpower, the British control of Iraq in the 1920s, Caren Kaplan, following Sven Lindqvist, refers to the British approach of controlling territory through airpower as “control without occupation.”³⁰ Surely, the idea that such control over territory does not constitute occupation is a claim that could only be made by an occupying power. Bypassing the sovereignty of these formerly colonial territories, these drone operations repeat, as Thomas Hippler has argued, the pattern of colonial “police” bombing that constituted one of the early uses of airpower.³¹ Indeed, it is in the first, “gentle” phase of the flying island’s domination of the ground below, rather than in the possibility of genocidal destruction, that Swift’s imagination of airpower links up with the future of colonial aerial domination.

What drones enable, for Hippler, is a “perpetual low-intensity war” that resembles a police action more than it does a traditional war strategy.³² In part, this is because it does not necessarily aim at peace, or at the end of war. Whereas Swift’s imagination moved gradually toward a more and more destructive form of domination, the twenty-first-century drone, and its more extreme remoteness, allows for a more or less permanent fixing of Swift’s first stage of dominance. Drones can hover indefinitely over a territory, killing those below when necessary. Hippler distinguishes this kind of war from classical air warfare, which involved heavy and very destructive bombing. He likens perpetual low-intensity warfare to the kind of colonial police bombing practiced by the British Empire in the 1920s in Iraq, as well as in territories like Waziristan, which is now, of course, subject to

the CIA's covert drone program. This perpetual low-intensity warfare is "conducted in regions that are officially at peace," and Hippler argues that it is thus "tempting to say that imperial perpetual peace now coincides with a perpetual low-intensity war."³³ On the one hand, this kind of warfare is nothing new. It is paradigmatic of a colonial form of conflict that never respected the laws or ideals of warfare between nation-states and especially the idea that peace is the end of war. Indeed, Mary Favret has argued that British citizens in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries lived in a perpetual state of remote warfare, while Eyal Weizman has argued that the "militarization of all spheres of life" in 1970s Israel means that "war was only over because it was now everywhere."³⁴ What drones allow, however, is a hyperbolic extension of this perpetual low-intensity war, because even those doing the killing do not have to risk their lives. The asymmetry is so hyperbolic, and the capacity to extend remote, drone occupation so little limited, that the global regime of drone colonialism can indeed appear perpetual. Drones are police-like, because they discipline societies theoretically at peace, but they conduct policing activities on a global scale and with a military force that, through its very remote operation, insulates the policing agent from reprisals or from serious resistance.³⁵ They are, as Hippler insinuates, a technological solution to the political problem posed by colonialism, that of ruling at a distance.³⁶

ASYMMETRY AND RACE

The final book of *Gulliver's Travels* explicitly introduces racial distinction into the problem of colonial rule. This form of asymmetry is crucial to understanding the problem of the drone and the way in which Swift's Enlightenment political imagination is linked to our present moment. Drones solve the problem of ruling at a distance only through the intense asymmetry between those who use drones and those who are subject to them. In another echo of the early history of aerial warfare, in which it was the colonial territories and peoples that were at first uniquely subject to aerial bombing, drone warfare is used only on racialized subjects, the value of whose lives is always an open question.³⁷ Indeed, as Woods and others have argued, the very status of civilian is not open to those people of North

Africa or the Middle East who are subject to drone warfare.³⁸ What makes the remote occupation characteristic of the drone possible, then, is not only a technological asymmetry, in the sense that the territories patrolled by drones have no air defense systems at all, in contrast to the highly advanced systems of the United States, but also a political technology of racism. This latter technology is an inheritance of the Enlightenment and creates, at the same time that a universal humanity is proclaimed, a system of distinctions between humans. Eyal Weizman demonstrates how the discourse and logic of humanitarianism in the Israeli politics of separation has become folded into the military logic of separation itself.³⁹ In this sense, the idea of a universal humanity is politically ambiguous, and certainly weaker, as a locus of resistance to state power, than the various political modifications of the category “human,” such as civilian, citizen, or even, as Hannah Arendt demonstrated with regard to post–World War II refugees, criminal.⁴⁰

As Achille Mbembe has argued, the logic of sovereignty, especially in its colonial guise, is dependent on race. For Mbembe, who follows Foucault in this sense, race is a “technology aimed at permitting the exercise of biopower, ‘that old sovereign right over life and death.’” This form of racially based biopower is, he argues, at its most hyperbolic in the colonies. “The colony,” he states, “represents the site where sovereignty consists fundamentally in the exercise of power outside the law . . . and where peace is more likely to take on the face of war without end.”⁴¹ He writes that this colonial situation of lawlessness “stems from the racial denial of any common bond between the conqueror and the native.”⁴² This asymmetry is so extreme that, Mbembe argues quoting Hannah Arendt, when “European men massacred them [natives of colonial territories] they somehow were not aware that they had committed murder.” Echoing Hippler’s concern about a perpetual low-intensity war, Mbembe writes that “peace is not necessarily the outcome of a colonial war. In fact, the distinction between war and peace does not avail.”⁴³ This logic of racialized colonial sovereignty is certainly operative in the political technology of drone warfare. As Chris Woods points out, even though the United States claims to be involved in a global war on terror, the majority of those killed by drones outside the hot battlefield have been Pashtuns, Yemenis, Afghans, and other people from the Gulf States or northern Africa.⁴⁴ Drone war thus has a decidedly colonial form in which, explicitly or implicitly, there is a clear racial

distinction between those who are subject to this new technology and those who are not. Even Woods's own book, which is otherwise a staunch critique of drone warfare, lists as an appendix only the "Westerners" killed by drones. Drone warfare thus seems to tally nicely with Mbembe's description of the late modern colonial political situation.

If drone warfare shares this racist logic of colonialism, however, it is also somewhat different because the presence of the occupier is, at least potentially, merely virtual. While even the late modern colonialism represented either by South African apartheid or, still more recently, by the Israeli occupation of Palestine is based upon a physical presence of the occupier in the occupied territory, drone warfare is a form of remote occupation. Western drone warfare undoes the concept of the presence of the occupier, allowing the conditions of occupation to persist even without an occupying presence. One of the difficulties in discussing drone warfare in terms of colonialism is terminological; it is precisely, as I examined in chapter 2, whether such a remote presence can still be called occupation. This very debate is a function of the way drone warfare works. In order to follow the contours of this debate, it is worthwhile to examine further Mbembe's account of late modern colonialism as well as Weizman's brilliant description of Israel's architecture and technology of occupation in Palestine. What these accounts share is an increased focus on verticality, on the idea that colonial sovereignty is no longer exercised in a two-dimensional way on the surface of the earth. Weizman in particular shows that in the various systems of tunnels and bridges and even the digging of wells, the landscaping and the architecture of Israeli settlements perform a kind of occupation that divides territory vertically, separating Israelis from Palestinians as completely as possible even as they live on the same stretch of earth. As he puts it, "The principle of separation has turned ninety degrees . . . with Israelis and Palestinians separated vertically, occupying different spatial layers."⁴⁵ This is an occupation that also deconstructs the presence of the occupier in that the radical separation performed by this politics of verticality means that as far as possible, Israelis and Palestinians do not live present to each other, even as they live in the same territory.

Indeed, this is the primary distinction that Mbembe draws between the occupation of Palestine and the South African system of apartheid. Clearly seeing Israel's vertical sovereignty as a brutal advance in the technology of

colonial occupation, Mbembe compares it with the earlier form of colonial occupation represented by apartheid. Mbembe writes that apartheid in South Africa is a perfect example of colonial occupation, which is a matter of “seizing, delimiting, and asserting control over a physical geographical area.” It is, Mbembe writes, following Frantz Fanon, “regulated by the language of pure force [and] immediate presence.” In this sense, to some degree the occupiers share the territory with the occupied. Colonial occupation “was, ultimately, tantamount to the production of boundaries and hierarchies, zones and enclaves; the subversion of existing property arrangements; the classification of people according to different categories; resource extraction; and, finally, the manufacturing of a large reservoir of cultural imaginaries. These imaginaries gave meaning to the enactment of differential rights to differing categories of people in the same space.” In this classical form of colonialism, then, the technology of racism was used to create a system of separation, apartheid, within a territory physically occupied by more than one category of person. Colonialism in this paradigm is about the territory of the surface of the earth. As Mbembe puts it, “Space was the raw material of sovereignty.”⁴⁶

When, following Weizman’s lead, Mbembe moves to talk about the form of occupation Israel performs in Palestine, he turns to the concept of vertical sovereignty. Rather than being merely about the territory, and the surface of the earth, this kind of occupation works in three dimensions. It is this form of three-dimensional verticality that Swift’s flying island literalizes. Mbembe argues that “under vertical sovereignty colonial occupation operates through schemes of over and under-passes, a separation of airspace from the ground.” He thus shows the way in which the occupation of the skies is essential to a late modern colonialism. For Mbembe, this form of occupation works toward a new form of apartheid, what he calls a “*splintering occupation*, along the lines of the splintering urbanism characteristic of late modernity (suburban enclaves or gated communities).”⁴⁷ What Mbembe, writing in 2003, focuses on is the network of roads, including overpasses and underpasses, that separate as fully as possible Israeli communities from Palestinian. Following Weizman, he shows how this system uses verticality to produce a separation of people.

Mbembe, however, does not write about drones in “Necropolitics.” This is possibly because drone warfare was not as prominent in 2003 as

it has since become. Weizman, in the final chapter of *Hollow Land*, which was published in 2007, talks about the technological advances in drone warfare, and how that has produced a new form of vertical occupation in Israel after the withdrawal of Israeli boots from the ground of the West Bank. Weizman notes that Israeli military planners referred to the phase that would follow the withdrawal of Israel from the West Bank as “the occupation that will follow the Occupation.”⁴⁸ In this form of occupation the old ideal, according to one Israeli Air Force commander, that “victory equals territory [is] anachronistic.”⁴⁹ It is in this sense that the aerial occupation of Palestine, carried out by drones, but also by other forms of airpower, most resembles the Laputan domination of Balnibarbi. It is about control of population rather than about staking a physical claim on territory. In this context, Weizman makes an argument about contemporary Israeli politics that aligns with the concept of sovereign (ir)responsibility, discussed in chapter 1, as well as with my claim that any politics of verticality is also a politics of a sovereign decision as little mediated as possible. Weizman argues that Israel’s program of targeted assassination from the air (in which drones are involved in surveillance, killing, or both) involves a new system of “fast-tracked political decisions” in which a special ministerial committee deliberates, typically for no more than fifteen minutes and typically without objections, on the validity of a target for assassination.⁵⁰ The immense amount of information collected by drones, as well as its real-time applicability, thus speeds up the political process of targeting. This increase in velocity fundamentally changes the political technology of democracy by removing distance (in the form of judicial, political, or ethical checks and balances) between a sovereign decision and an act of violence. This political technology is not incidental to drone warfare but is its corollary and condition of possibility, and it is only by thinking through a deconstruction of the sovereign decision that the deadly politics of verticality, in the sense of both airpower and sovereign power, can be combatted. This decision is central to the final book of *Gulliver’s Travels*.

HOUYHNHNM ASYMMETRY

Having spent some time looking at the political and racial technologies that are the conditions of possibility for drone warfare, let us now return to *Gulliver's Travels*, this time to Gulliver's final voyage. Interestingly, Swift presents us in this voyage with a radical form of asymmetry between the all-too-human Gulliver and his perfectly rational Houyhnhnm masters. At the same time, he represents a society entirely controlled by a racialized logic, in which both Houyhnhnm society itself and the relation between the Houyhnhnms and the Yahoos are primarily organized according to ineradicable and immediately visible racial distinctions. As Aravamudan writes, "The Houyhnhnms segregate according to clearly demarcated racial criteria."⁵¹ The racist resonances of this kind of segregation cannot be explained away by Rawson's detailed reading of the relation between the Houyhnhnms' inter-species (rather than inter-racial) difference from the Yahoos nor by his claim that the distinction maintained between different classes of Houyhnhnm is a distinction of class or rank rather than race.⁵² (I will return to this latter point.) Despite the clear and asymmetrical distinction between the Houyhnhnms and the Yahoos, however, the domination of the Yahoos is not the result of a high-speed process of political decision making. Instead, the Houyhnhnms' coexistence with the Yahoos is maintained in the extended temporality of an interminable decision. The only subject of debate in Houyhnhnm society, Gulliver tells us, is what to do about the Yahoos. If Swift's vision in *Laputa* imagined something of the technological future of drone warfare, it was mediated by a political reciprocity that ameliorated the asymmetry between those on the island and those subject to its rule. In the final voyage to the land of the Houyhnhnms, Swift's imagination anticipates the racist and colonial political future in which, however swiftly political decisions are made, it is the indefinite deferment of a decision to radically exterminate the racialized colonial subject that produces the brutal colonial present, a present that is maintained by killing, a killing that always stops short of extermination.

As readers of *Gulliver's Travels* know, the final voyage presents us with a society that Gulliver sees as perfectly ordered. Indeed, after leaving Houyhnhnm-land and returning to England, Gulliver is so disillusioned with the horrors of humanity that he can hardly bear to be around humans

and spends most of his time talking to domesticated horses. It is an open question to what extent Swift endorses this radical misanthropy.⁵³ What must be noted, in any case, is that Gulliver is “made to observe” by his Houyhnhnm master “that among the Houyhnhnms, the *White*, the *Sorrel*, and the *Iron-Grey*, were not so exactly shaped as the *Bay*, the *Dapple-grey*, and the *Black*; nor born with equal Talents of the Mind, or a Capacity to Improve them; and therefore continued always in the condition of Servants, without ever aspiring to match out of their own Race, which in that Country would be reckoned monstrous and unnatural” (236). Gulliver, as he does on most of his travels, thus adopts the vision or point of view of the Houyhnhnm, learning to observe difference and hierarchy among horses. The visibility of status difference among the Houyhnhnms undergirds both an aesthetic and a social order and precludes any kind of social mobility or aesthetic mixture. Importantly, this status order is domestic to Houyhnhnm society, but Swift borrows it from the emerging colonial technology of race.

This is indeed what Gulliver finds attractive about the Houyhnhnm system of status difference. This well-ordered society with minimal social mobility recalls an earlier passage in *Gulliver's Travels* concerning asymmetry. While in Brobdingnag, Gulliver had boasted to giants many times his size, waving his tiny sword, that he could take on any monkey that dared to attack him. He reports, however, “that my speech produced nothing else besides a loud Laughter” and that this “made me reflect how vain an Attempt it is for a man to Endeavour doing Himself Honour among those who are out of all degree of Equality or Comparison with him. And yet I have seen the Moral of my own Behavior very frequent in *England* since my Return, where a little contemptible Varlet, without the least Title to Birth, Person, Wit, or common Sense, shall presume to look with Importance, and put himself upon a foot with the greatest Persons of the Kingdom” (115). Here we see the specific concern with social mobility in England. Even though the contemptible varlet is completely unequal in all his parts, there is no clear visible marker that would force him and others to recognize this inferiority immediately. For that reason, England is plagued by attempts to move, or match, out of “race.” In Houyhnhnm-land the technology of racial difference, discovered in the colonies, becomes a fantasized solution for the more racially homogeneous but increasingly class-mobile

society of England.⁵⁴ Despite Rawson's insistence that distinctions among Houyhnhnms are not racial, it is the colonial technology of racism that acts as a solution to problems of status mixing.⁵⁵

If Gulliver seems to enjoy the idea of an obvious visible system to distinguish contemptible varlets from their betters, the relation between the Houyhnhnms and the Yahoos is both more violent and more ambiguous. While the Yahoos are recognizably human creatures, they are also human creatures who bear specifically racialized features. Gulliver writes, "I observed, in this animal, a perfectly human Figure; the Face of it indeed was flat and broad, the Nose depressed, the Lips large, and the Mouth wide. But these Differences are common to all Savage Nations" (213).⁵⁶ The Yahoos, then, do not simply represent humanity as such, but a humanity of the savage nations, those nations specifically subject to colonial rule and, of course in many cases, to the slave trade. While Rawson, for instance, is surely correct in arguing that for Swift the Yahoo represents us all, our commonality with the Yahoo is made visible only through the detour through the racialized other. Race, in this sense, does double work in the fourth voyage. It both divides and orders the Houyhnhnms' own social relations and produces an absolute gap between the rational horses and the beastly Yahoos, a gap that makes the Yahoos subject not only to forced labor but potentially also to elimination.⁵⁷

As stated above, Gulliver tells us that the Houyhnhnms, who are otherwise so rational that they are unable to see the point of disputing over anything, nevertheless have one major subject of debate: what to do about the Yahoos. Strikingly, the temporality of this decision is in stark contrast to that of all their other decisions, something that becomes clear in Gulliver's description of their quadrennial General Assembly. Gulliver tells us that this assembly, which seems purely administrative rather than political, involves decisions that are barely, or not at all, worthy of the name. He says that the Houyhnhnms "inquire into the State and Condition of the several Districts; whether they abound or be deficient in Hay or Oats, or Cows, or *Yahoos*? And wherever there is any Want (which is but seldom) it is immediately supplied by unanimous Consent and Contribution" (248). The immediacy is important here, as it demonstrates that there is no deliberation but that the distribution of goods is something merely subject to calculation. In this sense, this is not at all a political decision. On the

other hand, during the assembly held in Gulliver's time, the Houyhnhnms resumed "their old Debate" (248). In contrast to the handling of administrative particulars, this debate is seemingly interminable, pure deliberation without the possibility of coming to a decision or solution. It was, Gulliver tells us, "indeed the only Debate which ever happened in that Country," and it concerned "whether the *Yahoos* should be exterminated from the Face of the Earth" (249). There is in the Houyhnhnms' inability to come to a decision a suspension of the political, similar to the refusal of the United States to officially declare war on, or even admit that they are acting within, territories they nevertheless attack by drone. The political technology of the drone (not simply the technical aspect of the drone itself but also the entire administrative apparatus that allows for its operation) is thus made possible by the radical suspension of the political.⁵⁸

The Houyhnhnms thus suspend a decision in order to maintain a seemingly untenable political situation. They are certain that the Yahoos are unteachable and naturally degenerate. However, the Houyhnhnms, for all their rationality, have grown used to Yahoo labor and "have very imprudently neglected to cultivate the Breed of *Asses*, which were a very comely Animal, easily kept, more tame and orderly, without any offensive Smell, [and] strong enough for Labour" (249). The Yahoos are thus contemptible but also useful or indispensable, and their survival depends entirely on the impossibility of deciding, definitively, to exterminate them. The Yahoo present is thus the extended time of Houyhnhnm deliberation, a present punctuated by forced labor and violence but extended indefinitely. This is a specific temporality that involves the deliberate deferment of extermination. More than just a "tease sustaining an already considerable readerly discomfort," Swift's silence about the outcome of the Houyhnhnm debate produces an extended present.⁵⁹ This deferment of decision is, further, not only a way of maintaining the satiric point that the Yahoos (us) deserve extermination, as Rawson argues, but the production of a present in which continual lower-level punishments and humiliations are justified. Deferring extermination produces and maintains the radical asymmetry that characterizes the relationship between the Houyhnhnms and the Yahoos. This is the colonial present of those subject to the logic of the drone. While outright extermination is precluded, the lives of those under drones are so little valued that an extended present punctuated by acts of violence and

constant surveillance seems, within this logic, unavoidable. It is here that the technology of race allows the drone to function and that the technology of the drone extends the racist and colonial present indefinitely. Indeed, the drone is the prosthesis of extension, not just of the senses of the drone operator, who can see and act from half a world away, but of the present itself, rendering the possibility of permanent surveillance punctuated by death possible.

If, in the first chapter, we saw a decision that happened in a zone of sovereign (ir)responsibility, looking at Swift's account of the Houyhnhnms opens up another dimension of the political decision characteristic of the drone. The decision to kill via drone is always a substitute or placeholder or deferral of another decision, a decision that cannot be made because it seems unthinkable, outside the neoliberal logic of the drone. However, not making this decision to exterminate the people whose lives have nevertheless been rendered unworthy of the status of civilian, citizen, or even active combatant makes possible the constantly repeated decision to kill those same people one by one. Each killing by drone is thus now and present but also haunted by a future that cannot come but that nevertheless produces the killing in the present. Drone warfare exists not just in an asymmetrical space, in which those in particular parts of the world are vulnerable to the radically asymmetrical violence and power of drone warfare, but also in an asymmetrical temporality, in which the actual violence of the present is allowed and justified by the suspension of a hyperbolic spectral future violence of extermination.